

CONFIDENTIAL



How do you actually become a VC?

VC Academy Launch • Taipei

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Chairman & Managing Director,
Mosaic Venture Lab

Volker Heistermann

Co-founder, Mosaic Venture Lab



Before we start — who are you?

Hands up if you're here because...

01 You want a job in venture capital

02 You've started a company and you're thinking about investing in others

03 You already write cheques and you want to get better at it

04 You're just curious

Two seats at the table



JOHNNY YU

Taipei

Chairman & Managing Director,
Mosaic Venture Lab

- Active investor in Taiwan
- Term sheets and due diligence
- Raised 2 US\$100M VC funds at Yuanta Securities
- Sits inside the companies, not just on the cap table



VOLKER HEISTERMANN

Silicon Valley

Co-founder, Mosaic Venture Lab
Managing Director, Yushan Ventures

- 30 years in Silicon Valley's ecosystem
- Technology scouting for Volkswagen Group and Audi across 25+ countries
- Co-created the APEC Accelerator Network
- Venture Partner at TPTF, US\$100M AUM

Between us: Silicon Valley, Berlin, Tokyo, Taipei.

\$510B

GLOBAL VENTURE FUNDING · FIRST SIX MONTHS OF 2026

YOY COMPARISON

More capital than all of 2025 combined.

MARKET CONCENTRATION

Roughly 43% of it went to two companies.

The myth that stops most people

"It's a job you apply for."

There is no recruiting season.

There is no structured intake.

Most firms hire around two events: a new fund closing, or somebody leaving.

THE REALITY

If you're waiting for the posting, you'll wait.

Five things a VC does

SOURCE

Find companies before anyone else does

JUDGE

Decide fast, and usually no

WIN

Persuade the good ones to take your money

SERVE

Board seats, hiring, introductions, bad news at 11pm

RAISE

Go and ask LPs for the next fund

The first two are open to you before anyone hires you.

Four routes in

1

The Operator

You built something. You know one industry from the inside. Funds hire you for the domain, not the finance.

2

The Domain Expert

Semiconductors, materials, biotech, hardware. Taiwan's advantage. Deep-tech funds cannot diligence what they cannot understand.

3

The Scout or Angel

Small cheques, real decisions, a track record you own. The only route with no gatekeeper.

4

The Analyst

Research, platform, or CVC. The traditional door, and the narrowest one.

All four run on the same fuel: somebody already inside vouches for you.

Scouting: the door nobody guards

What a scout does

Finds deals a fund would never see. Writes a short view. Passes it to a partner.

What a fund gives back

Access, sometimes a small carry, sometimes an introduction that changes your career.

What it costs you

Nothing but judgment — in public, on the record, repeatedly.

Your track record starts with the first deal you have a written opinion on. Not the first cheque you write.

Johnny — how did you get in?

THE EARLY OPPORTUNITY

**The first deal I saw
before anyone else**

THE CHAMPION

**The person who
vouched for me**

THE LESSON

**The thing I got wrong
early — and what it cost**

A QUICK CHALLENGE

How many companies does a venture fund look at to make one investment?

A **10**

B **50**

C **200**

D **1,000+**

The Funnel

Per year. One team.

1,000+

SOURCED

250+

QUALIFIED — basic diligence

70

SHORTLISTED — real diligence

3–5

INVESTED

Most of this job is a fast, well-reasoned no

1 A bad no costs you one deal.

2 A slow no costs you a reputation.

3 A yes you can't defend costs you the fund.

Every deal passes three gates

GATE 1 • THESIS

Does this belong in my fund at all? Sector, stage, geography, ticket size.

Most deals die here, in under five minutes.

GATE 2 • SHAPE

Can I get the ownership I need at a price I can defend? Who else is in — am I leading or following?

The round structure decides the answer, not the company.

GATE 3 • CONVICTION

Can this team plausibly return my whole fund?

The only gate where the founder matters more than the spreadsheet.

Your turn. Three deals. Sixty seconds each.

You have US\$1 million and a thesis: early-stage deep tech in Taiwan.

1

Write it down first

On your handout: **I** for invest, **P** for pass, and one word for why. Before anyone speaks.

2

Commit on three

We count to three and everyone votes at once. **Thumb up = invest.**
Thumb down = pass.

3

No abstaining

A real partner meeting has no maybe. You will be asked to defend whichever way your thumb went.

No discussion until all three are done. Then we tell you what we did — and where we disagreed.

"Northbridge"

A low-power inference chip that runs small language models on industrial equipment, with no cloud connection.

STAGE **Series A**

RAISING **US\$12M**

PRE-MONEY **US\$48M**

FOUNDED **2022 · Hsinchu**

TEAM

Three co-founders, ex-MediaTek and ex-Novatek
CTO holds 14 patents in low-power SRAM design
Nobody on the team has ever sold to a customer outside Taiwan

TRACTION

Two paid pilots with Tier-1 Taiwanese ODMs
NT\$18M booked in 2025 · first tape-out scheduled Q1 2027
NVIDIA Inception member; named in two analyst reports

THE CATCH

A Tier-1 corporate investor will fund the entire round — on the condition of two-year design exclusivity in their category.

Market context: Taiwan AI-silicon rounds run large — one energy-efficient inference chip startup raised NT\$640M; sector median deal size is US\$1.96M.

**Thumb up =
invest**

**Thumb down
= pass**

"Meridian"

Software that reads heart rate and respiratory rate from an ordinary camera, with no sensor touching the patient.

STAGE **Series A extension**

RAISING **US\$4M**

PRE-MONEY **US\$22M**

FOUNDED **2020 · Taipei**

TEAM

Spun out of a national university lab; the founder is the professor, still teaching two courses

First commercial hire made fourteen months ago

Clinical trials run with a major Taipei teaching hospital

TRACTION

US FDA 510(k) clearance on two measurements, plus TFDA

Deployed in three hospitals and one elderly-care chain

NT\$9M revenue in 2025, growing roughly 30% a year

THE CATCH

Six years old and roughly US\$300K of revenue. Two competitors hold the same clearances and have raised ten times as much.

Market context: Taiwan has 264 healthtech companies but only 48 funded, US\$292M raised in total — and 14 have already reached IPO.

**Thumb up =
invest**

**Thumb down =
pass**

"Lantern"

Simulation software that lets a factory build and test a new production line virtually before spending a dollar on it.

STAGE **Seed extension**

RAISING **US\$6M**

PRE-MONEY **US\$30M**

FOUNDED **2023 · Taipei**

TEAM

Two founders — one ex-Foxconn automation, one robotics researcher

Eleven engineers, all in Taipei

No international sales experience on the team

TRACTION

Four paying factory customers, all Taiwanese

NT\$40M in signed multi-year contracts

A large Taiwanese EMS group wants to lead the round and take a board seat

THE CATCH

If that group leads, every competitor of that group stops being a customer — and probably stops being an acquirer.

Market context: corporate investors took part in around 72% of Taiwanese deals in Q1 2025. This is the normal shape of a Taiwan round, not an edge case.

**Thumb up =
invest**

**Thumb down
= pass**

What you just did in 60 seconds

A real process takes six weeks.

YOU SAW

A one-pager

YOU SKIPPED

The diligence question set built for your thesis

The founder's non-answers

Customer references

The cap table & the term sheet

The ownership math

What happens when the next round doesn't come

Every one of those is learnable. None of them fits in an afternoon.

The Three Worlds of VC

Silicon Valley vs. Taiwan vs. China |
VC Academy Taipei Teaser



The Gravity of Capital Changes with Your Coordinates

What works in Palo Alto will get you fired in Beijing and ignored in Taipei. The operational mechanics of VC—risk, sourcing, and exits—change completely based on your location.

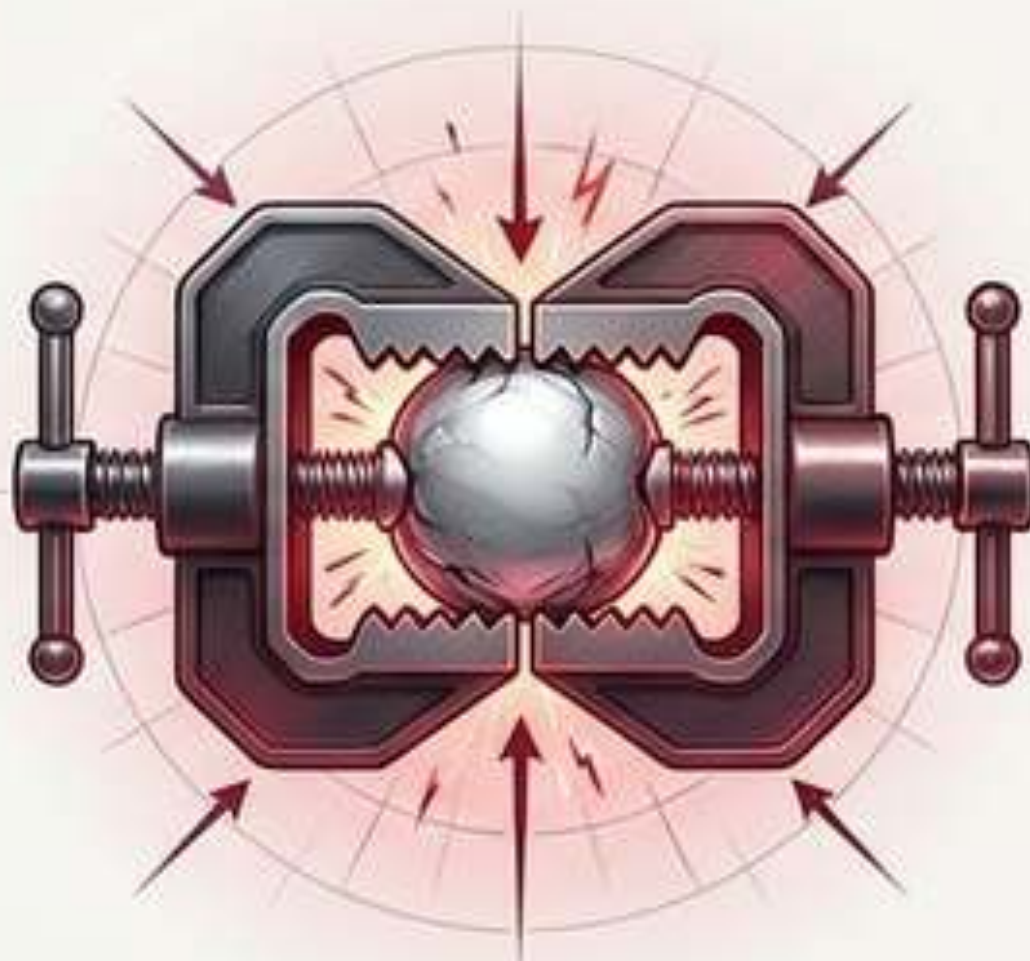
PALO ALTO



Frictionless Growth:

Low resistance, rapid ascent, network effects, abundant capital.

BEIJING



Immense Pressure:

Regulatory squeeze, intense competition, government influence, high stakes.

TAIPEI



Complex Interlocking:

Supply chain integration, precise engineering, deep technical expertise, niche dominance.

Silicon Valley: The Open Ecosystem

Driven by transparency, fluid capital, and accessible opportunities.



What the Valley looks like right now

>70% of Q2 capital went to AI companies

\$217B raised by OpenAI and Anthropic combined in H1

32 venture-backed companies IPO'd above \$1B in Q2 alone

\$106.5B assets under management at a16z, the largest VC firm

The money got bigger. The number of decisions did not.

How a Valley round actually runs

SPEED

A competitive seed round can close in days. Not months.

STANDARD PAPER

SAFEs and standard templates. Nobody argues about boilerplate.

SIGNALLING

Who else is in the round tells other investors more than the deck does.

REFERENCES OVER DECKS

The diligence that matters is calls about the founder, not the model.

THE PARTNER MEETING

One person champions it. If nobody will champion it, it dies quietly.

Why one deal has to carry everything

Most investments return nothing.

A few return the fund.

One returns everything.

In one dataset of 1,808 early-stage investments, **1% of the ones that made money returned 22x or more.**

This one piece of math explains every VC behaviour that looks irrational from the outside.



TOP PERFORMER METRIC

22x+

Returned by the top 1% of profitable early-stage deals

China: The Gladiator Arena



The Reality of “明股实债”

Ostensibly equity, in reality **debt**.



The Stakes

Mandatory **6-8 year hurdle returns** with total personal founder liability.



The Exit

Go Public or Go Home. A virtually non-existent M&A market.

Navigating the Shadow Networks

Municipal RMB / USD Funds

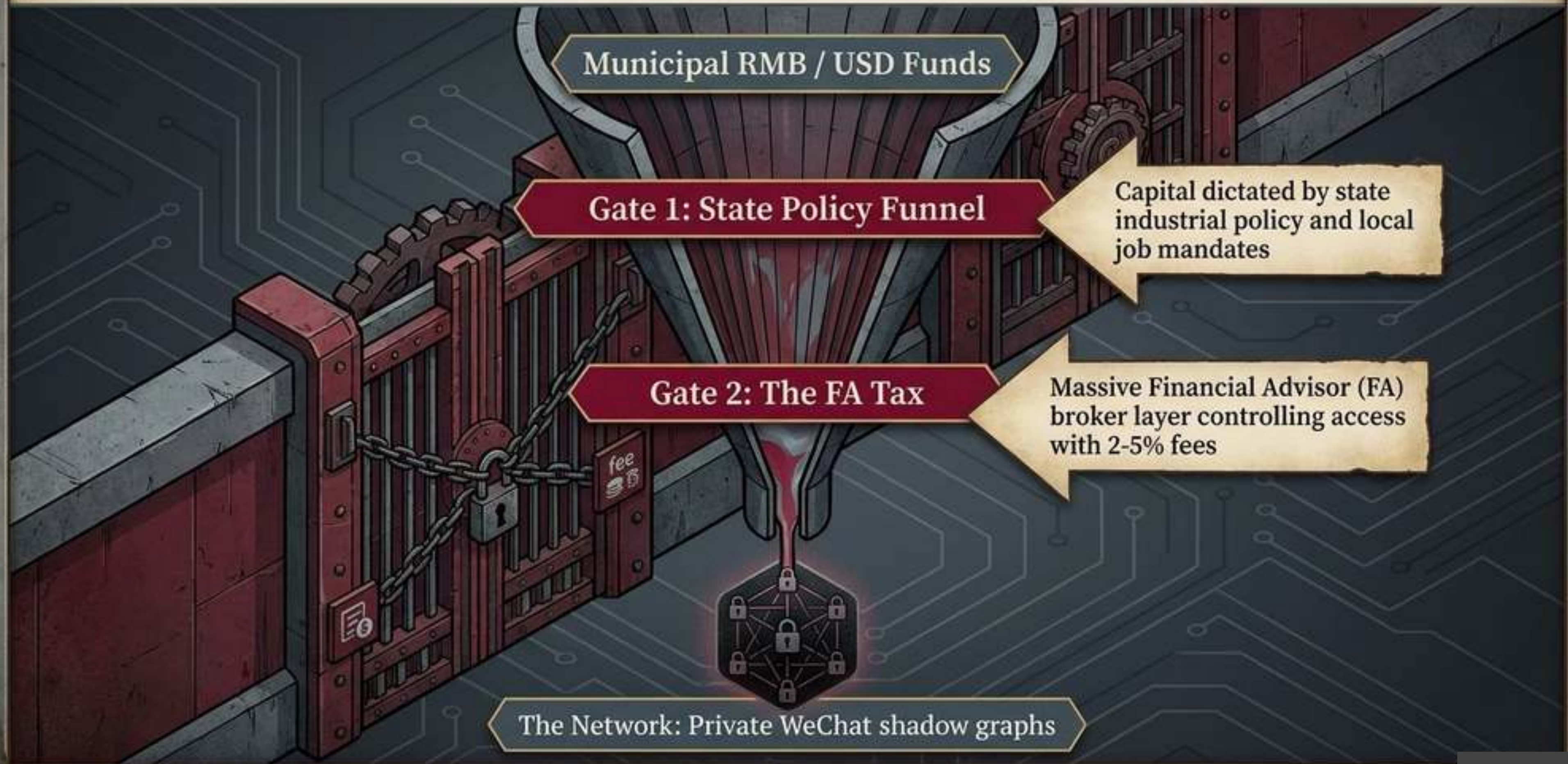
Gate 1: State Policy Funnel

Capital dictated by state industrial policy and local job mandates

Gate 2: The FA Tax

Massive Financial Advisor (FA) broker layer controlling access with 2-5% fees

The Network: Private WeChat shadow graphs



Taiwan: The Deep Tech Engine



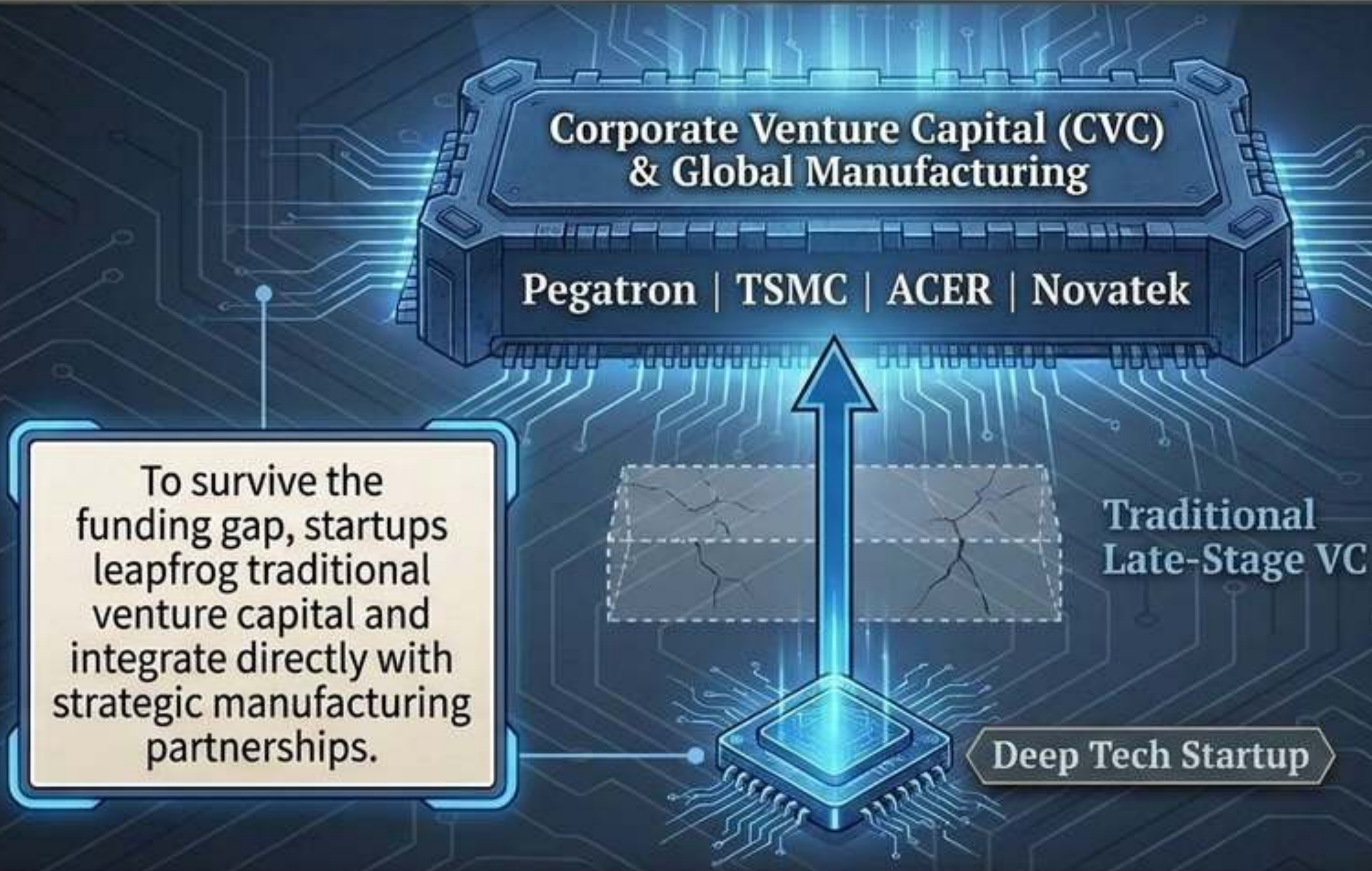
The Strength

Unmatched deep tech and engineering talent.

The Constraint

A smaller domestic market where traditional VC capital dries up right when companies need to scale.

The Taiwanese Playbook: The CVC Stack



Listing early and small

Taiwan's unique public capital ladder

2,200

Companies listed in Taiwan

An incredibly deep public market for a technology ecosystem of this scale.

900

Worth under US\$100M

A company that size cannot list in the United States at all.

60%

Retail participation in trading

Small caps turn over their entire market cap three to four times a year.

THE PUBLIC ESCALATOR LADDER

興櫃 Emerging Stock



TPEX Board



TWSE Main Board



Innovation Board

No profitability requirement to list on the first rung. A recommending securities firm guides the company up the ladder.

The exit isn't a trade sale. It's a public listing — earlier and smaller than a Silicon Valley investor expects.

The Master Matrix: Global VC Mechanics

	Silicon Valley	China	Taiwan
Dominant Capital	True Risk Equity	Municipal RMB / USD Funds	CVC & Strategic Partners
Founder Liability	Zero	Total (Personal Repurchase)	Low
Deal Network	Open / Thought Leadership	FA Brokers / WeChat	Corporate Pilots / Supply Chain
Exit Reality	M&A / Soft Landings	IPO Only (Go Public or Go Home)	Strategic Acquisition

What travels from the Valley to Taipei

TRAVELS

VOLKER

01 The three gates

Thesis, shape, conviction are questions about your fund, not about the market. They work the same in Taipei.

02 References over decks

What decides it is calls about the founder. Nothing about that is geographic.

DOESN'T TRAVEL

JOHNNY

01 Speed and standard paper

A SAFE and a handshake close a Valley seed in days. Here the lead is often a corporate with an investment committee and a strategic agenda, and every term is negotiated.

02 The power law as a portfolio rule

Taiwan lists early and small. A fund that only backs companies which could return everything will pass on most of what actually works here.

Taiwan, right now

US\$3.34B

across 605 deals — startup funding, 2024. Highest annual total since 2015.

US\$1.96M

median deal size · US\$5.83M average

75 IPOs

in 2025 raising NT\$107.6B, up from 67 IPOs and NT\$57.6B in 2024

**24
companies**

listed on the Taiwan Innovation Board through March 2026

NT\$10B

National Development Fund angel programme budget, extended to 2030

2nd

supportive startup conditions

20th

as a startup ecosystem overall

The gap between those two numbers is the whole story.

The gap

72%

of Taiwan deals in Q1 2025 had corporate investors taking part

22%

around 22% had traditional VCs taking part

Taiwan has capital. What it's thin on is a professional early-stage judgment layer.

Corporates invest for strategy. Government invests for policy. Both are rational.

Neither is the same job as venture.

If you want in, the timing is unusually good

The money is arriving

NT\$10B in angel programme budget, an AI investment programme, a fintech fund raising now.

The listing route is opening

TIB reforms through 2025 and 2026 cut custody periods and opened the board to retail investors.

The judgment layer is thin

With fewer people dissecting opportunities properly, quick movers capture asymmetric positioning.

"Capital without judgment is just a queue. Somebody has to be qualified to be at the front of it."

Where the deals actually are

The universities and ITRI

The research is real; commercialisation is the bottleneck.

The semiconductor supply chain

Three conversations from almost any hardware startup in Asia.

Corporate scouting mandates

Audi, Continental, LITEON+ and others are actively looking.

The event circuit

Meet Taipei, Computex, Innovex.

Returnees

Founders coming back from the US and Japan with a network on both sides.

None of these are secret. Almost nobody works them systematically.

Four things the people who get in have

A thesis

A specific view about a specific corner of the market, written down.

Proprietary deal flow

Companies you see that the fund doesn't.

Reps

Decisions you've made and been held to, on the record.

The room

People already inside who will vouch for you.

Nobody is born with these. All four are built.

Ask us anything

SOME THINGS PEOPLE USUALLY WANT TO KNOW

What does a first-year VC actually get paid?

How do you tell a good founder from a good talker?

Can I do this part-time while I keep my job?

What's the biggest deal you missed?

Is Taiwan too small a market to build a fund on?

Term sheet parameters

Valuation

Investment structure

Liquidation preference

Anti-dilution

Participation rights

Voting rights

Board representation

Founder and employee vesting

Drag-along and tag-along

Registration rights

Redemption rights

Pro-rata rights

Information rights

Exit provisions

How many of these could you argue about?

You Can't Learn Global Venture from a Podcast



Frameworks & Standard Equity



Local Traps & Shadow Networks

Junior VCs fail because they don't know the unwritten mechanics, the local term sheet traps, or how to navigate shadow networks and CVC integrations.

We don't teach theory. We teach the craft.

Four pillars. In person. In Taipei.

01**THE ECOSYSTEM**

A working map. Who invests in what, at what stage, at what size — Silicon Valley, Japan, Korea, Europe, and here.

02**ROLES & DILIGENCE**

Lead, anchor or co-investor. Building the few questions that matter. Passing early, with conviction.

03**TERM SHEETS & DEAL**

The language, the document, the cap table, the tools. Taught on real deals.

04**THE BUSINESS OF VC**

Fund economics, portfolio construction, the power law, exits. Why VCs behave the way they do.

How it runs

In Person

At the Taipei office

Not a webinar. A collaborative, in-person room.

Evenings / Weekends

Keep your job

Structured to fit around existing professional commitments.

~10 people

Small cohort

Small enough that you will be asked to defend a real position.

Real Deals

Live materials

Actual term sheets, cap tables, and active diligence sets.

PROGRAMME SPLIT & PRACTICE FOCUS

20%

Concept

45%

Real cases

20%

Mentor debrief

15%

Your own reps

Who it's for

Aspiring professionals

Students and analysts who want the job and a proven path into venture capital.

Operators & founders

Builders about to start writing angel cheques and sitting on corporate boards.

Family offices

Members who need to read, evaluate and structure the deals they are offered.

Early-stage investors

Investors who want proprietary access to early-stage deals and know how to read them.

Who it is not for: anyone looking for a certificate. There is a lot of homework.

Who teaches it

CORE FACULTY

Volker Heistermann

Johnny Yu

Ken Huang

THE MENTOR CIRCLE

Chander Kant — K Ventures

Todd Lin — Semiconductor & M&A (ex-GE, Acer, Egis)

Mentors take part voluntarily. The lineup is confirmed per cohort.

BEFORE NEXT FRIDAY

Pick one company. Write 300 words on why you would or wouldn't invest. Date it.

Send it to someone whose opinion you respect.

| That's rep number one.

| If it's terrifying, that's the right one.

Thank you

Come and argue with us. The bar is open.

We're both here for the next hour to take questions, chat deals, or debate the Taipei ecosystem.

Volker Heistermann

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One minute. Honest feedback. It helps us make the next session better.